

CHAPTER 2

Your First Real Project

From blank page to finished project — the process

Step	What you do	What it teaches Claude
Brain dump	Tell Claude everything — goals, constraints, obstacles, reality	Context: the more you share, the better the output
First structure	Read what comes back — don't respond yet	Claude organizes your chaos into a starting point
Push back	Tell it what won't work and why	Refinement: eliminate dead ends Claude can't see
Get specific	Ask for dates, numbers, daily actions — not categories	Specificity: the level of detail you ask for is the level you get
Stress test	Ask Claude to poke holes in the plan	Critique: find what breaks before you start
Polish	Ask for a clean final version, organized the way you'll use it	Finish: turn the conversation into a deliverable

Prompts Worth Stealing

Here's everything in my head about [project]. [Dump it all – goals, situation, constraints, timeline, budget, obstacles.]

This won't work because [specific reason]. Rebuild this section with that constraint in mind.

Make it specific. Give me a week-by-week plan with daily actions I can check off.

Look at this plan as a skeptic. What's most likely to fail? Where am I being unrealistic?

Give me a clean final version I can print and follow. Start with the goal, then the plan, then what to track.

This reference card is a companion to Chapter 2 of Creating with Claude by Chris Thatcher. More reader resources at marquepublishing.com/reader.